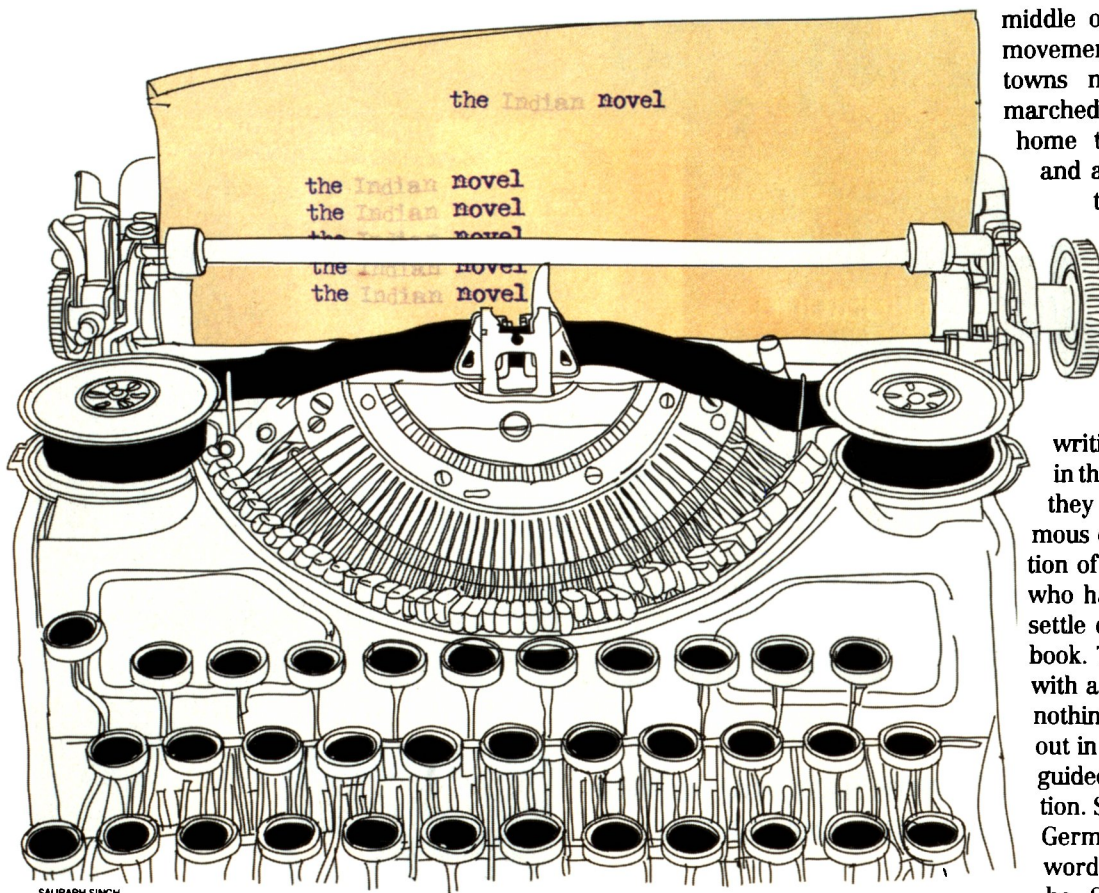




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between native and evolved? Or do they belong more to the publishing culture of Britain and the United States? The question has to be asked, because no national literature has ever been created like this, at such a remove, where the books are published by people outside, judged by people outside, and to a large extent bought by people outside.

In the nineteenth century Dostoevsky and Turgenev and Gogol and Herzen lived for some time outside their native Russia; but they wrote in Russian for Russian readers and (for all of them except Herzen) Russia was where they were published and had their readers. Russia was where their ideas fermented.

Nineteenth-century Russian writing created an idea of the Russian character and the Russian soul. There is no equivalent creation, or the beginning of one, in Indian writing. India remains hidden. Indian writers, to speak generally, seem to know only about their own families and their places of work. It is the Indian way of living and consequently the Indian way of seeing. The rest of the country is taken for granted and seen superficially, as it was even by the young Nehru, until some desperate, ragged villagers, in the

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or its literary quality or the point of view of the writer. Much keeps on being said in the Indian press about Indian writing as an aspect of the larger modern Indian success, but literary criticism is still hardly known as an art. The most important judgements of an Indian book continue to be imported.

As much as for Gandhi, born in 1869, and for Chaudhuri, born in 1897, India's poverty and colonial past, the riddle of the two civilisations, continue to stand in the way of identity and strength and intellectual growth.

*Excerpts from A Writer's People: Ways of Looking and Feeling by V.S. Naipaul, Picador India, Rs 395, 192 pages.*

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middle of an angry agrarian movement that no one in the towns nearby knew about, marched to Allahabad, Nehru's home town, in June 1920 and asked him to come to their villages and see the conditions in which they lived.

The education of the new Indian writers—and nowadays some of them have even been to writing schools—also gets in the way. It seems to them they have the most enormous choice when, in imitation of the successful people who have gone before, they settle down to do their own book. They are not bursting with a wish to say anything; nothing is going to force itself out in its own way; they are guided in the main by imitation. Should they be Irish or German and indulge in wordplay? Should they be South American and

see magic everywhere? Should they be like the late Raymond Carver and pretend they know nothing about anything? Or should they simply talk it over with their teacher at the writing school? This is where India begins to get lost. The writing school's India is like the writing school's America or Maoist China or Haiti.

India has no means of judging. India is hard and materialist. What it knows best about Indian writers and books are their advances and their prizes. There is little discussion about the substance of a book